

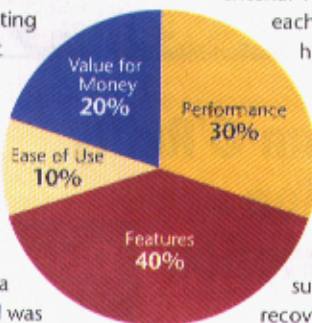
Digit Test Process

The test bed used to evaluate the system suites consisted of a Pentium 4 2.0 GHz processor on an Intel 845GBV motherboard, 256 MB or DDR RAM and a 40 GB 7,200-rpm hard disk. The OS was Windows 98 SE. We split the hard disk into two partitions—the operating system resided on the first partition, while the second partition was loaded with data for our file recovery and data recovery tests. The first partition was in a fragmented state, as it was created from an image of a hard disk in active use and was used for the defragmentation tests.

We evaluated the System Suites based on performance, features, ease of use and value for money.

Performance: To evaluate each suite based on the extent of resources that it consumed, we measured the time taken for a system to boot up, both before and after installing a system suite. Moreover,

the difference in CPU and RAM utilisation was noted down using the Windows System Monitor and a third-party utility—Cacheman 5.11, respectively. Defragmentation of a hard disk was the second criteria. We noted the time taken by each package to defragment the highly fragmented primary partition. The faster it was, greater were the points awarded to it. We also noted the decrease in the size of the system registry by running the registry optimising utilities that came along with the suites tested. Finally, the data recovery options were tested on the basis of file recovery and format recovery tests. To test the former, we deleted files from the second partition and then used the suites to recover them. Marks were awarded in accordance with the number of files successfully recovered. To test format recovery, the second partition was formatted. The data recovery tool was then run and the amount of data recovered was logged.

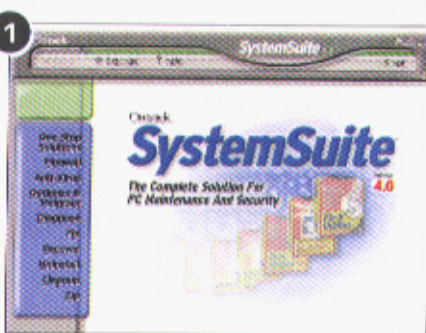


Features: A system suite is basically a set of tools bundled together and a greater variety of tools helps you perform more tasks and eliminate the need to separately buy utilities. We also considered the support offered by the developers. The FAQs available on the vendor's site, along with online help (e-mail contact of the support person) and real-time chat facility were all regarded as value-adds.

Ease of Use: The accessibility to the various features of the application was evaluated. This included descriptive icons, intuitive menu structures, presence of wizards, etc. The ability to create a bootable rescue disk and the number of OSes supported by a suite was also given due consideration.

Value for Money: This is a factor of the performance and features offered by the System Suites as compared to its price. Therefore, the greater the performance and features and the lower the price, the higher will be the value for money offered by each package.

a snap to get the job done. The interface is very well designed—the icons are big, sporting the now fashionable aqua look a



1. Ontrack SystemSuite 4.0

2. McAfee Utilities

Both McAfee and Ontrack have a legible interface with clear text and icons

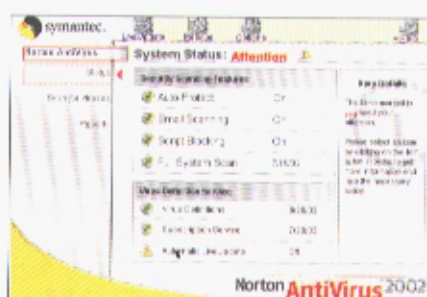
la Mac OS X and are very functional. McAfee similarly sports a very well-designed look that is easy on the eyes—it's quite similar to that of Ontrack. Although the icons used are not very self-explanatory, you will not have to devote much time to understand what each one stands for.

Norton has a very simple interface that gets the job done quickly and efficiently.

System security: The bane of the Net has been that it poses a significant security risk to both end-users and corporations alike. To secure your system against these malevolent entities, you need anti-virus software. Anti-virus tools not only check your mail for viruses, but also scan the machine on a regular basis to detect the presence of viruses and most of them accomplish this by protecting your system through all of the possible ports of entry—via e-mail, shared files and removable drives.

All the suites came bundled with a fully featured anti-virus utility. Norton SystemWorks 2002 offers free updates of virus definitions for one year while Ontrack SystemSuite 4.0 bundles VirusScanner Pro.

A firewall is as important for protec-



Norton offers free annual virus definition updates

tion from Trojan and hacker attacks. Only Ontrack SystemSuite 4.0 offered a firewall—from Sygate Technologies—but it offers very basic protection.

Permanent data erasing is another security feature that is a must for those who have critical and sensitive files on their system that need to be reliably deleted. Office users in particular will find this feature enticing—if your PC has been transferred to someone else at work, this utility will be handy in preventing others from accessing your deleted data. The Ontrack suite was the solitary provider of this important feature.

System Maintenance: A computer system tends to slow down after continuous